Digital Ecosystem & Building Routines.

Institutional Capacity Workshop · ITC YEP · Banjul · Friday

What we agreed yesterday

Three threads from Thursday — carried into today.

Communicative, not structural

The gap is in how The Gambia is told, not what it has to offer. Institutions can help close it.

Enablers, not marketers

Set standards, provide tools, coordinate narratives — making it easier for hundreds of SMEs to communicate well.

Routine beats sophistication

A simple habit done consistently every month is worth more than a complex study done once.

Today

Digital ecosystem and institutional visibility — then a simple monitoring routine — then priorities and commitments.



SESSION 5

Digital Ecosystem and Institutional Visibility

Governance, platform ownership, and partnerships — the things institutions can do that no SME can.

What already exists

The question is not 'do we have a digital presence?' — it's whether that presence is current, accurate, consistent, and maintained.

Official websites

Tourism portal and institutional pages exist — but when were they last reviewed for accuracy?

Social media accounts

Accounts exist across platforms — but posting frequency, tone, and links to booking vary widely.

Google TripAdvisor listings profiles

The first thing visitors see in search — hours, addresses, and photos that may be outdated.

TripAdvisor listings

Destination and attraction pages exist — but ownership, monitoring, and response protocols are often unclear.



Three common problems — and one named risk

These affect most destination digital ecosystems in developing countries.

01

Outdated information

Hours, prices, and contacts that are no longer accurate — visitors find wrong information before they arrive

02

Inconsistency

Different messages on different channels — visitors cannot build a coherent picture of what The Gambia offers

03

Abandonment

Accounts and pages that were created and then left — low activity reads as low credibility to international visitors

04

Digital orphans

Platforms created by projects that end without a handover plan — appear credible but contain outdated information, actively undermining trust

“

Platform governance and continuity identified as a systemic gap across Gambian creative industry stakeholders.

— DELIVERABLE 1, BASELINE ASSESSMENT

SESSION 5

Who Owns What

Platform governance is an organisational question, not a technical one.

Four questions every institution should answer

For each major platform: website, social media accounts, Google Business profile, TripAdvisor listing.

01

Admin access

Who has the login? Is it one person or shared? What happens when that person leaves?

02

Update responsibility

Who is responsible for keeping content current? Is this written into their role, or assumed?

03

Handover process

Is there a documented process for transferring access when staff change? Has it ever been tested?

04

Review schedule

When was the platform last reviewed for accuracy? Is there a calendar trigger, or does it happen reactively?

Platform audit — a practical starting point

Conduct a platform audit: list every official digital touchpoint and assess it against four questions.

Step 1 — List

Every official touchpoint: website, social accounts, Google Step 4 — Risk flag, TripAdvisor, any project platforms. If it exists, it's in scope.

Step 2 — Date

When was each platform last updated? Note the date — anything over three months without activity is a flag.

Step 3 — Owner

Who has administrative access? Name a person, not a team. If nobody knows, that is itself a finding.

Step 4 — Risk flag

Outdated, unowned, or inconsistent — flag it. These are the platforms that require urgent governance attention.



SESSION 5

Destination-Level SEO

What institutions can do that no individual SME can.

What SEO means at destination level

When someone searches “Gambia travel” or “things to do in The Gambia,” what do they find?

The institutional role

Creating and maintaining the central content hubs that other sites link to — and that search engines treat as authoritative.

What good looks like

Accurate, compelling, up-to-date — reflecting the full range of what The Gambia offers, including creative industries.

Language matters

French-language content is almost entirely absent. Francophone visitors represent 15% of current reviews but could be far higher.

What to maintain

Event listings, experience descriptions, operator contacts — updated regularly, not just when something changes.



Content aggregation — the institutional superpower

Individual SMEs cannot do this. Only institutions have the reach, mandate, and credibility to bring it together.

What aggregation means

Bringing together information about events, experiences, and operators in one accessible, searchable, bookable place.

The evidence

Deliverable 2, Digital Lever 10: Creative Tourism Calendar & Operator Toolkit — interactive calendar aggregating craft, festival, and heritage events. Estimated impact: HIGH · effort: MEDIUM.

What it includes

Festival calendar, craft market schedule, heritage site opening hours, booking contacts — updated before each season.

Why it works for SEO

A single authoritative hub that operators, OTAs, and bloggers link to — building domain authority and visibility for the whole destination.



SESSION 5

Partnerships Institutions Can Broker

The leverage no individual SME has — used on behalf of the whole sector.

Three partnerships only institutions can broker

Each requires credibility and relationships that individual SMEs do not have.

01

OTA partnerships

Negotiate destination-level agreements with Booking.com, TripAdvisor Experiences, GetYourGuide — making it easier for SMEs to list and be found

02

Media & press

Facilitate visits by travel journalists, bloggers, and content creators covering The Gambia — institutions identify, invite, and host

03

Operator fam trips

Organise familiarisation visits for international tour operators — the most direct route to being included in operator portfolios

04

Why it matters

81% of pure Gambia tours score below 20/100 on creative tourism content. Operator relationships are the single most effective lever to change this

“

Curated storytelling partnerships, bookable creative products, ready-to-use bilingual materials.

— DELIVERABLE 2, §3.4

SESSION 5

Seasonal Visibility & Crisis Response

Presence year-round, and a protocol when things go wrong.

The off-season problem

Tourism is seasonal. Source-market audiences planning their trips are not.

The timing gap

UK and Dutch visitors plan 3–6 months ahead. If The Gambia is invisible online in April, it loses bookings in October.

What year-round presence means

Content that covers the full calendar — events, seasons, experiences — published when source markets are planning, not when visitors are arriving.

The festival opportunity

Festivals and cultural events are natural content hooks. Coverage before, during, and after an event maintains visibility across the whole planning cycle.

What institutions do

Coordinate a content calendar aligned to the festival and cultural events programme — shared across GT Board, NCAC, and sector associations.



A simple crisis response protocol

Agree on this before you need it. One person, one threshold, one tone.

MONITOR

Watch for signals

1

One named person per institution checks reviews, social mentions, and press weekly

DECIDE

Apply the threshold

2

Any review below 3 stars on an official platform — respond within 48 hours. Agree this in advance.

COMMUNICATE

Use the agreed tone

3

Responses are professional, factual, and resolution-focused. Never defensive. Tone guidelines documented.

“

Tour operators: sentiment +0.32, rating 4.7/5.
The Gambia’s best digital ambassadors are already working.

— DELIVERABLE 2, §4.3 · NEGATIVE FEEDBACK FOCUSES ON TRANSPORT, NOT SERVICE

EXERCISE

05

Digital Health Checklist

⏱️ 15 MIN

WHAT YOU'LL DO

1 Assess individually or in pairs

Use the one-page checklist: website currency, social media activity, TripAdvisor accuracy, Google Business completeness, operator presence. Rate each: ✅ good / ⚠️ needs attention / ❌ gap. (8 min)

2 Share back

Brief group discussion: which items scored worst? Any surprises? (4 min)

3 One action each

Each participant names one item from the checklist they will act on in the next month. (2 min)

4 Fallback if offline

Use pre-printed examples: one strong destination ecosystem (e.g. Cape Verde), one weak, and The Gambia. Groups compare and discuss. Same outcome. (1 min)

Achievable with existing capacity

No new budget, no new staff, no specialist technology. Governance, process, and coordination.

Governance

Know who owns what. Document it. Build in a handover process before the next staff change, not after.

Process

Agree a response protocol, a content calendar, and a review schedule. Write them down. Assign them to roles, not individuals.

Coordination

Share what you find. A platform audit shared across institutions reveals more than one conducted in isolation.

Next — Session 6

Building a simple monitoring routine — what to track, how often, and how to share intelligence with SMEs.



SESSION 6

Building a Simple Intelligence Routine

Low-tech, low-cost, high-consistency. A habit, not a system.

What good monitoring looks like — and what's realistic

Not comprehensive reports. Awareness of direction — and early warning when things go wrong.

The goal

Maintain awareness of whether things are moving in the right direction — and catch problems early enough to respond.

The key word

Routine. A simple check done consistently every month is more valuable than a sophisticated analysis done once every two years.

What it is not

Not a research project, not a commissioned study, not a dashboard that requires specialist tools or dedicated staff to maintain.

What it requires

Time, a clear set of questions, and a willingness to share findings across institutions. Nothing more.



“

Routine beats sophistication. Every time.

— SESSION 6 FRAMING PRINCIPLE

Three questions a monitoring routine should answer

If you can answer these three questions quarterly, you have a functioning monitoring routine.

REACH

Are we being found?

1

By the right audiences, in the right places, before they travel

EXPERIENCE

Is the visit as intended?

2

Are the people who visit having the experience we want them to have?

TRAJECTORY

Are things improving?

3

Getting better, stable, or declining — over months and years, not feelings

SESSION 6

A Simple Monitoring Framework

Three routines, three different rhythms — each answering a different question.

Three routines — three different rhythms

Each answers a different question. Together they give a complete picture.

01

Quarterly

Operator catalogue check — 10 operators, same questions, simple spreadsheet, compare quarter-on-quarter

Monthly

Review sentiment scan — 20 most recent TripAdvisor reviews, recurring themes, flag responses, track trend

03

Annual

Benchmarking snapshot — same framework as baseline, year-on-year comparison, one shared spreadsheet

04

The principle

Same questions, same sources, same person — consistency of method is what makes trends visible

Quarterly operator catalogue check

Visit 10 operator sites. Ask the same questions every time. Record in a simple spreadsheet.

Which 10 operators

Choose the 10 that most influence Gambian inbound volumes — UK, Dutch, German, and West African specialists. Keep the list consistent.

Four questions each

How is The Gambia described? Which experiences are featured? What images are used? Are creative industries present?

Record and compare

Same spreadsheet, same columns, quarter after quarter. The value is in the trend, not the individual observation.

What to act on

A new operator picking up Gambia, a key operator dropping creative content, or a persistent misrepresentation — each warrants a direct response.



Monthly review sentiment scan

Read 20 most recent TripAdvisor reviews. Note themes. Flag anything requiring a response.

What to read

The 20 most recent reviews for key attractions and the destination overall — sorted by date, not rating.

What to note

Recurring positive themes (what is consistently working), recurring negative themes (what is consistently failing), anything surprising.

What to flag

Anything requiring a response — a cluster of negative reviews about a specific issue, a very low rating without a reply, a mention that could spread.

What to track

Whether overall sentiment is improving, stable, or declining. A simple note in a shared file. One line per month is enough.



Annual benchmarking snapshot

Once a year, assess The Gambia using the same framework as the baseline. Compare year-on-year.

What to assess

Social media presence, website functionality, online discoverability, booking capability — the same six dimensions from Deliverable 2.

Why the same framework matters

Consistency of method is what makes year-on-year comparison meaningful. A different framework each year produces incomparable data.

How long it takes

Half a day, once a year — split across two or three institutions if the workload is too much for one team.

What to do with it

Share with all monitoring institutions and present to SMEs at the annual meeting. A one-page summary with year-on-year changes is enough.



The starting KPI set

Deliverable 2, Table 20 — ready-made framework. Baseline 2025 → Target 2026.

INDICATOR	BASELINE 2025	TARGET 2026
ITO creative visibility	52%	60%
Avg sentiment score	+0.24	+0.30
Verified TripAdvisor reviews	39 (2024)	+25% increase
Average review rating	4.06	4.20

These four indicators can be tracked with free tools and shared quarterly across institutions — no specialist software required.

SESSION 6

Sharing Intelligence with SMEs

Monitoring has limited value if findings stay within institutions.

Three ways to share — choose the one most likely to happen

The goal is to translate intelligence into guidance that SMEs can act on — without adding reporting burden.

01

One-page briefing

Quarterly summary of what the data shows and what it means for SMEs — emailed to operators and sector associations

02

Email alert

Short update when something significant changes — a new operator picks up Gambia, a cluster of negative reviews appears on a specific issue

03

Annual meeting

Institutions share findings, SMEs respond with ground-level experience — builds shared understanding and surfaces what data cannot show

04

The tone that works

“Here is what we are seeing and what it might mean for you” — guidance, not evaluation. Not judgment of individual businesses.

“

“Here is what we are seeing — what does it mean for you?”

— THE TONE FOR SHARING INTELLIGENCE WITH SMEs

SESSION 6

Monitoring as Coordination

Shared data creates shared understanding — the foundation for coordinated action.

The quarterly coordination call

2–3 hours per quarter. Return: avoid duplication, respond consistently, spot opportunities.

SHARE

What each institution observed

1

Each institution presents what it has seen — operator portfolios, reviews, social, any incidents

IDENTIFY

Common themes

2

What patterns appear across institutions? What issues keep surfacing? What looks like an opportunity?

AGREE

Joint responses or actions

3

What will be done together before the next call? Who is responsible? What does success look like?

Who convenes?

Ref Deliverable 2, §6.3 — GT Board as lead coordinator and custodian of the Digital Positioning Opportunities Matrix.

Lead: GT Board

Convenes and chairs quarterly meetings. Holds the shared monitoring spreadsheet and distributes findings to participating institutions.

Core: NCAC

National Centre for Arts and Culture — owns the creative industries data and brings the cultural programme perspective to monitoring discussions.

Extended: sector associations

Hotel association, craft associations, tour operator federation — invited participants who bring ground-level intelligence no platform data can provide.

The minimum viable version

A 90-minute call between GT Board and NCAC, once a quarter. Everything else is an enhancement. Start with this.



EXERCISE

06

Draft Your Monitoring Plan

⏱️ 20 MIN

WHAT YOU'LL DO

1

Draft individually (8 min)

One page: what you will track (3–4 indicators), how often, who is responsible (name a role, not the institution), and how you will share findings with SMEs.

2

Pair feedback (5 min)

Exchange plans with the person next to you. One piece of concrete feedback each — one thing that makes the plan more likely to actually happen.

3

Share-back (5 min)

What commitments have been made? Where could institutions support each other in maintaining the routine?

4

Alternate

If from a single institution: work as a group to produce one shared plan. Assign indicators to specific roles. Avoids the plan staying abstract.

What would make this routine stick?

20 minutes, open discussion — realistic barriers and how to address them.

Q1 — Barriers

What are the realistic barriers to maintaining this routine beyond the project cycle? Time, skills, political will — name them honestly.

Q2 — Mutual support

How might institutions support each other in keeping the routine going? What would a peer accountability mechanism look like?

Q3 — The anchor

Is there one person or one mechanism that could serve as the anchor for coordination beyond this workshop?

NB for facilitator

This session is deliberately low-tech. No new tools, no new budget, no new staff — only time, consistency, and shared willingness. Frame it as building a habit.



WRAP-UP

Priorities, Commitments & Coordination

Friday afternoon — participant-led. The facilitator synthesises and prompts.

PART 1

What We Learned

30 minutes — synthesis, reflection, grounding.

Facilitator synthesis — themes from the two days

Facilitator draws out 3–4 key themes. Populated live — these are prompts, not prescriptions.

Theme 1

[Facilitator note: the idea or finding that came up most repeatedly across the two days]

Theme 2

[Facilitator note: the tension or unresolved question that most needs naming]

Theme 3

[Facilitator note: the finding that surprised people most — or challenged existing assumptions]

Theme 4

[Facilitator note: the connective thread between the SME training week and this institutional workshop]

IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

Suggested: Gambian family at craft market, warm daytime light, 16:9 or 4:3 crop

Round-table — one thing that stuck with you

Each person identifies one finding or idea from the two days that was most useful or most surprising.

The question

What confirmed something you already believed? And what challenged it? Both are useful — but they call for different responses.

Format

Brief round-the-room share — one sentence per person. Facilitator notes recurring words or themes.

Facilitator note

The goal is not comprehensive synthesis — it is to surface what mattered most to the people in the room. Trust the group.

Time

Allow 1–2 minutes per person. If the group is large, ask for the most surprising insight only — keeps energy up.



PART 2

Priority Actions

45 minutes — one or two concrete actions per institution. Specific enough to be checkable.

EXERCISE

07

One or Two Concrete Actions

⏱ 45 MIN

WHAT YOU'LL DO

1 Identify your actions (10 min)

Each institution identifies 1–2 concrete actions for the next 3 months. Not “improve digital presence” — but “conduct platform audit and identify three outdated pages to update by June.”

2 Capture on the board (10 min)

Facilitator captures actions on shared board, grouped by theme: monitoring · content · coordination · SME support · platform governance.

3 Discuss coordination (15 min)

Where would coordination between institutions amplify individual efforts? Are there actions two or more institutions could do together more effectively?

4 Agree joint actions (10 min)

Are there any actions that belong to a group rather than a single institution? Name them, name who leads, and set a check-in date.

Actions grouped by theme

Facilitator populates this slide live from the board. These are the themes to organise around.

01

Monitoring

[Actions added live]

02

Content

[Actions added live]

03

Coordination

[Actions added live]

04

SME support & governance

[Actions added live]

Where does coordination amplify?

Discussion prompt — which actions from the board are better done together than separately?

The question

Are there any actions that two or more institutions could do together more effectively than separately? Name them.

Examples to prompt

A shared platform audit. A joint operator outreach. A co-hosted media familiarisation trip. A shared content library. Name what fits.

What joint action needs

A named lead, a clear division of responsibility, a check-in date, and agreement on what “done” looks like. Vague coordination fails.

Facilitator note

Don't force it. If no joint action emerges naturally, individual commitments are enough. The goal is momentum, not ambitious coordination that won't happen.



PART 3

Coordination Mechanisms

30 minutes — agree something specific and achievable. Not aspirational.

A minimum viable coordination mechanism

Agree on this before you leave the room. Specific format. Named participants. First date.

WHO

GT Board + NCAC + sector associations

1

Quarterly check-in — willing participants only. A small committed group is more valuable than a large reluctant one.

WHAT

Share, identify, agree

2

Each shares what it has observed. Common themes identified. Any joint responses or actions agreed before the next meeting.

HOW

Call, meeting, or shared doc

3

Whatever format is most likely to actually happen — not the most impressive, the most sustainable. Choose it now.

If there's appetite for more

The quarterly call is the minimum. These are enhancements — worth discussing if energy and capacity allow.

A shared briefing note

A lightweight quarterly or bi-annual newsletter shared across institutions and select SMEs — what the monitoring shows, what it means, what to watch.

A shared monitoring spreadsheet

One document, updated by all participating institutions, showing the four KPIs and any notable findings — visible to all without a meeting.

An SME intelligence brief

A short quarterly email to operators and craft associations — two or three data points and one action they can take based on what the institutions are seeing.

The test

Would this still happen in 18 months without a project team supporting it? If the honest answer is no, start with the minimum and build from there.



“

Maintain momentum.
Don't start something new.

— CLOSING FRAME FOR THE WORKSHOP

One word — round the room

Each person says one word or phrase that describes what they are taking away from the two days.

Format

Go around the room in order. One word or short phrase each. No explanation required — just say it.

Facilitator note

Note the words on the board. They will often cluster in ways that reveal what the group valued most — useful feedback for the project team.

Then

Facilitator closing remarks: acknowledge the investment made across the week, summarise the connective thread between SME training and this workshop, name the next step.

Formal close

The next step is not starting something new. It is maintaining what has been built this week.



Thank you.

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